

I'll continue using the new reference's broad-family approach: not only the learner-core senses, but established constructions, specialist domains, related family forms, and important semantic traps.

Word family: **defend / defends / defended / defending / defence / defense / defensive / defensively / defensiveness / defender / defensible / indefensible / undefended / defendant**

Base word: defend

Past tense: defended

Past participle: defended

** -ing form:** defending

Major related forms:

* **defence** — BrE

* **defense** — AmE

* defensive

* defensively

* defensiveness

* defender

* defensible

* indefensible

* undefended

Important related legal word:

* defendant

Lower-priority/specialist forms:

* defensible

* defenceman / defenseman

* defensin / defensins

Part of speech: verb (動詞)

Family nouns/adjectives: defence/defense, defender, defensive, defensible, defendant

Your sentence:

> “Admittedly, some people **defend this practice by arguing** that many Hong Kong students do not have quiet homes...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **defend** means **to argue in support of a practice that has been criticized, explaining why you believe it is reasonable or justified**.

****繁體中文： ** **為.....辯護；替.....辯解；提出理由支持 / 維護某種做法****

****中文翻譯： ****

> “Some people ****defend this practice by arguing that****...”

「有些人****為這種做法辯護，理由是****.....」

Here:

****defend a practice = 當某種做法受到批評時，提出理由說明它為甚麼合理、可以接受或值得支持

This is ****argumentative defence****, not physical protection.

A. PHYSICAL PROTECTION

1. ****defend someone/something = protect against physical attack (保護) — 保衛；保護；防衛

This is the central literal meaning.

Practice 1

> “The soldiers ****defended**** the village.”

「士兵****保衛****了村莊。」

Practice 2

> “Animals will often ****defend**** their young.”

「動物往往會****保護****自己的幼兒。」

Practice 3

> “The walls were built to ****defend**** the city.”

「這些城牆是為了****保衛****城市而建。」

****defend = 阻止攻擊者傷害、奪取或破壞某人 / 某地 / 某物****

2. **defend against an attack = resist an attacker (抵禦) — 抵禦 ; 防禦**

Practice 4

> “The town was difficult to **defend against** attack.”

「這座城鎮很難**抵禦攻擊**。」

Pattern:

> defend X **against** Y

= 保護 X , 使其免受 Y 攻擊。

3. **defend someone from something = protect them from harm (防止受到) **

Practice 5

> “The shield helped **defend** him **from** flying debris.”

「盾牌幫助**保護**他免受飛散碎片傷害。」

Both occur:

* defend against

* defend from

But **defend against** is especially common when emphasizing an active threat or attack.

4. **defend oneself = protect oneself physically (自衛) — 自衛 ; 保護自己**

Practice 6

> “She raised her arms to **defend herself**.”

「她舉起雙臂**保護自己 / 自衛**。」

This can be physical or verbal depending on context.

5. **defend one's home/property = protect it against intrusion (保衛財產) **

> “He tried to defend his property.”

「他試圖**保護自己的財產**。」

The focus is active resistance rather than merely general protection.

B. MILITARY / NATIONAL SECURITY

6. **defend territory/country/border = resist military attack (軍事) — 防衛 ; 保衛**

Practice 7

> “The forces were deployed to **defend** the border.”

「部隊被部署以**保衛邊境**。」

Common:

- * defend the country
- * defend the homeland
- * defend the border
- * defend the territory
- * defend a position

7. **defend a position = prevent an enemy taking it (陣地) — 守住 ; 防守**

Practice 8

> “The unit was ordered to **defend the position**.”

「該部隊奉命**守住陣地**。」

This phrase can later become figurative:

> defend a position in an argument.

8. **defend airspace = protect controlled airspace against threats (空防) — 保衛領空**

A military/security domain application.

9. **defence/defense = protection against attack (防衛) — 防禦；保衛**

Practice 9

> “The city strengthened its **defences**.”

「這座城市加強了**防禦工事 / 防衛能力**。」

Plural:

> **defences/defenses**

can refer to:

- * walls
- * fortifications
- * weapons
- * protective systems

10. **national defence / national defense = 國防**

Broadly:

> systems, forces, institutions, and activities concerned with defending a country.

Common compounds:

- * defence policy
- * defence spending
- * defence forces
- * defence industry
- * defence contractor

These are institutional/domain extensions rather than separate meanings.

11. **air defence / missile defence / cyber defence**

Examples:

- * air defence = 防空
- * missile defence = 飛彈防禦
- * cyber defence = 網絡防禦

All belong to the protective branch.

12. **civil defence / civil defense = civilian protection system (民防) **

Historically and institutionally, systems designed to protect civilian populations during emergencies, attacks, disasters, etc.

Exact organizational scope varies by jurisdiction.

13. **defence in depth / defense in depth = layered protection (縱深防禦 / 多層防禦) **

A strategy of using multiple independent protective layers rather than depending on one barrier.

Used in:

- * military strategy
- * nuclear safety
- * cybersecurity
- * engineering risk management

C. ARGUE IN SUPPORT / JUSTIFY

14. **defend an idea/practice/decision = argue that it is justified (辯護) — 為.....辯護；維護**

This is your passage sense.

Practice 10 — Original

> “Some people **defend this practice** by arguing that students lack quiet places to study.”

「有些人以學生缺乏安靜學習場所為理由，**替這種做法辯護**。」

Practice 11

> “She **defended** her decision.”

「她為自己的決定**辯護 / 作出解釋**。」

Practice 12

> “He strongly **defended** the proposal against criticism.”

「他面對批評時強力**維護**這項建議。」

15. **defend by arguing/explaining/saying that...**

The exact passage construction:

> defend X **by arguing that...**

= 透過提出某個理由來為 X 辯護。

Example:

> “They defended the change by arguing that it would save money.”

「他們以可以節省成本為由**為這項改動辯護**。」

16. **defend one's actions/conduct = justify one's behaviour (行為) — 為自己的行為辯護**

Practice 13

> “He found it difficult to **defend his actions**.”

「他很難為自己的行為**辯解**。」

Often implies:

> the actions have been challenged or criticized.

17. **defend a claim/argument/theory = present reasons/evidence supporting it (論證) — 捍衛 ; 論證**

Practice 14

> “The researcher must be able to **defend** her conclusions.”

「研究人員必須能夠提出理據**捍衛 / 支持**自己的結論。」

This is especially common in:

- * academia
- * philosophy
- * debate
- * research

18. **defend a position/view = justify an intellectual position (立場) — 捍衛立場**

> “Can you defend that position with evidence?”

「你能否用證據**為那個立場辯護**？」

19. **defend oneself against criticism = answer criticism (反駁 / 辯解) **

Practice 15

> “She defended herself against accusations of carelessness.”

「她針對別人指責她粗心一事作出**辯護**。」

Here there is no physical attack.

20. **defend one's reputation = protect reputation from criticism/allegations (名譽) **

> “He issued a statement to defend his reputation.”

「他發表聲明以**維護自己的聲譽**。」

This bridges:

- * argument;
- * protection.

21. **defend someone's honour/honor = protect their reputation/dignity (名譽) **

Formal/literary:

> defend someone's honour

= **維護某人的名譽 / 尊嚴**

22. **defend a principle/value/right = actively uphold it (捍衛) **

Common:

* defend freedom

* defend human rights

* defend one's rights

* defend a principle

* defend academic freedom

Here **defend** means:

> resist attempts to weaken, remove, or violate something regarded as valuable.

23. **defend one's right to do something**

Practice 16

> “She defended her right to express her opinion.”

「她**捍衛自己表達意見的權利**。」

This does not necessarily mean the right is under physical attack.

24. **defend the indefensible = try to justify something impossible to justify (固定表達) **

Practice 17

> “He was accused of trying to **defend the indefensible**.”

「有人指責他試圖替**根本無法合理辯護的事情辯護**。」

A strong rhetorical expression.

D. LEGAL DEFENCE

25. **defend someone in court = represent and argue for an accused/defendant (法律) — 為.....辯護**

Practice 18

> “The lawyer agreed to **defend** him.”

「律師同意為他**辯護**。」

Here **defend** means:

> act as legal representative in opposition to a criminal charge or civil claim.

26. **defend oneself in court = conduct one's own legal defence (自行辯護) **

> “He chose to defend himself.”

「他選擇在法庭上**自行辯護**。」

Exact procedural rights depend on the legal system.

27. **defend a case/action/claim = resist the opposing legal claim (法律) **

In civil procedure:

> defend an action

> defend a claim

> defend a lawsuit

can mean:

> respond to and resist the claim brought against you.

28. **defence/defense = legal arguments/evidence against a charge or claim (抗辯) — 辯護 ; 抗辯**

Practice 19

> “The defence argued that the evidence was unreliable.”

「**辯方**主張證據不可靠。」

Depending on context, **the defence** can mean:

1. the legal case/arguments;
2. the lawyers/side representing the accused.

29. **the defence / the defense = defence side (辯方) **

> “The defence called its first witness.”

「**辯方**傳召第一名證人。」

Common courtroom sense.

30. **criminal defence / criminal defense = 刑事辯護**

The legal work of representing people accused of crimes.

31. **defence counsel / defense counsel = 辯護律師**

> “Defence counsel questioned the witness.”

「辯護律師盤問證人。」

32. **defense attorney = 辯護律師 (AmE) **

Especially American legal English.

33. **public defender = public/legal-aid criminal defence lawyer (公設辯護人等) **

In jurisdictions using this institution, a lawyer providing criminal defence to qualifying defendants who cannot privately retain counsel.

The precise institutional model varies.

34. **legal defence = legally recognized argument against liability (法律抗辯) **

Examples may include doctrines such as:

- * self-defence
- * necessity
- * consent
- * limitation/time bars

depending on legal area and jurisdiction.

The exact requirements are legal-system-specific.

35. **affirmative defense / affirmative defence (美國法律等) — 積極抗辯**

A defendant raises additional facts which, if established, can defeat or reduce liability even if some elements of the claimant/prosecution case are otherwise established.

Specialist procedural term; definitions vary somewhat by jurisdiction.

36. **self-defence / self-defense = 自衛 ; 正當防衛**

Can mean:

ordinary

protecting yourself physically.

legal

a legal justification/defence for certain uses of force, subject to the applicable jurisdiction's requirements.

37. ****defence of another / defense of others****

Legal doctrine involving force used to protect another person.

Again, rules vary by jurisdiction.

38. ****statement of defence / answer/defense pleading****

In some civil-procedure systems, a formal document responding to a claim may be called a:

> defence / statement of defence.

Terminology varies by jurisdiction.

E. ****DEFENDANT****

39. ****defendant = person/entity against whom a legal case is brought (被告) ****

Practice 20

> “The ****defendant**** denied the allegation.”

「****被告****否認該項指控。」

Criminal context:

> person accused/prosecuted.

Civil context:

> person/entity against whom a claim is brought.

Important distinction: ****defender vs defendant****

****defender****

= someone who protects/defends.

****defendant****

= the party against whom a legal case is brought.

A defendant is **not necessarily the person doing the defending**.

Their lawyer may be the defender/defence counsel.

F. SPORTS — PROTECT THE GOAL / PREVENT SCORING

40. **defend = try to stop the opposing team scoring (體育) — 防守**

Practice 21

> “The team **defended** well in the second half.”

「球隊下半場**防守**得很好。」

Here **defend** can be intransitive.

41. **defend the goal/basket = protect scoring area (防守球門 / 籃框) **

> “They defended their goal effectively.”

「他們有效地**防守球門**。」

42. **defend an opponent/player = mark/guard them (盯防) **

Practice 22

> “Three players tried to **defend** him.”

「三名球員嘗試**防守 / 盯防**他。」

Especially basketball and similar sports.

43. **defend space/zone = protect an area (區域防守) **

> “The team defended the central area well.”

「球隊很好地**防守了中路區域**。」

44. **defend a lead = stop the opponent overturning your advantage (守住領先) **

Practice 23

> “They spent the final ten minutes **defending a one-goal lead**.”

「最後十分鐘，他們一直努力**守住一球優勢**。」

Very common sports reporting.

45. **defend a title/championship = compete to retain it (衛冕) — 衛冕**

A major distinct sports construction.

Practice 24

> “She will **defend her title** next month.”

「她下個月將會**衛冕**。」

Meaning:

> the current champion competes again and attempts to remain champion.

46. **defending champion = 衛冕冠軍 / 上屆冠軍**

> “The defending champion reached the final.”

「**衛冕冠軍 / 上屆冠軍**晉身決賽。」

47. **defence/defense = act/system of stopping opponents scoring (體育) — 防守**

> “Their defence was excellent.”

「他們的**防守**非常出色。」

48. **the defense = defending players/unit (防守組 / 防線)**

Especially American football:

> offense vs defense

= **進攻組 vs 防守組**

In association football:

> defence

can refer collectively to defensive players/back line.

49. **defender = defensive player (體育) — 後衛 ; 防守球員**

Practice 25

> “The defender blocked the shot.”

「那名**後衛 / 防守球員**擋下射門。」

Especially football/soccer.

50. **defenceman / defenseman = ice-hockey defensive player (冰球) — 防守球員**

A specific sports noun.

Spelling reflects regional **defence/defense** variation.

51. **defensive midfielder / defensive back / defensive end**

Fixed positional compounds in different sports.

These are applications of:

> defensive = primarily concerned with stopping attack.

52. **defensive rebound (籃球) — 防守籃板**

A rebound obtained by the defending team after the opponent misses.

G. CHESS / BOARD GAMES / GAMES

53. **defend a piece/square = prevent its capture/control (棋類) — 保護棋子 / 格位**

Practice 26

> “The knight **defends** the pawn.”

「騎士**保護**那隻兵。」

54. **defence/defense = opening/system used in reply to an opponent (西洋棋) — 防禦開局**

Examples of conventional names include:

- * Sicilian Defence
- * French Defence
- * King's Indian Defence

Here **Defence** forms part of the proper opening name.

55. **defender = defensive role in games (遊戲) **

In video/tabletop games, a **defender** may be:

- * a character protecting allies;
- * a defensive role/class;
- * the player/team preventing capture/scoring.

Domain extension of ordinary **defender**.

H. ACADEMIC ARGUMENT / THESIS

56. **defend a thesis/dissertation = justify it before examiners (學術) — 答辯；為論文辯護**

Practice 27

> “She will **defend her dissertation** next week.”

「她下星期會進行博士論文**答辯**。」

Meaning:

> present the research and respond to critical questions/challenges.

57. **thesis/dissertation defense/defence = 論文答辯**

Practice 28

> “He passed his doctoral **defense**.”

「他通過了博士論文**答辯**。」

The exact format varies by institution.

58. **oral defense = 口頭答辯**

Common academic term.

In British systems, some institutions instead use:

> viva / viva voce examination

depending on local terminology.

59. **defend a proposition/theory = provide rational support (哲學 / 學術) **

> “The author attempts to defend the claim.”

「作者嘗試對該主張作出**論證 / 辯護**。」

This is ordinary argumentative **defend** applied academically.

I. BIOLOGY / MEDICINE / IMMUNITY

60. **defend the body against infection (生物) — 抵抗感染**

Practice 29

> “The immune system helps **defend** the body against infection.”

「免疫系統有助**保護人體免受感染**。」

61. **immune defence / immune defense = 免疫防禦**

Broadly:

> mechanisms used by organisms to resist pathogens or harmful biological threats.

62. **host defence / host defense = 宿主防禦**

Common in immunology/infectious-disease writing.

> host-defense mechanisms

= 宿主抵抗病原體的機制。

63. **first line of defence = first protective barrier (第一道防線) **

Literal/biological

> “The skin is an important first line of defence.”

「皮膚是重要的**第一道防線**。」

Figurative

> “Regular backups are a first line of defense against data loss.”

「定期備份是防止資料遺失的**第一道防線**。」

Highly productive expression.

64. **biological/chemical defences = organisms' protective traits (生物防禦) **

Plants and animals may have:

- * physical defences
- * chemical defences
- * behavioural defences

Examples:

- * thorns
- * toxins
- * camouflage
- * defensive behaviour

65. **plant defence = 植物防禦反應**

Plants can defend against:

- * herbivores
- * pathogens
- * environmental stress

through structural and biochemical mechanisms.

66. **defensive behaviour = animal/human protective response (防禦行為) **

> “The animal displayed defensive behaviour.”

「動物表現出**防禦行為**。」

67. **defensin = antimicrobial peptide (生物化學) — 防禦素**

Defensins are families of small antimicrobial peptides involved in innate host defence.

Highly specialist family-related scientific vocabulary.

Not a normal derivative learners need for general English, but worth indexing at “fullest” level.

J. PSYCHOLOGY

68. **defense mechanism / defence mechanism = psychological mechanism protecting against distress (防衛機制) **

A major psychological term.

Examples traditionally discussed include:

- * denial
- * projection
- * rationalization

Different psychological traditions classify mechanisms differently.

繁體中文： ** **心理防衛機制

69. **defensive = reacting as if criticized/threatened (人際) — 防衛心重的；戒備的**

Very common everyday adjective meaning.

Practice 30

> “He became **defensive** when asked about the mistake.”

「有人問起錯誤時，他立刻變得很**防衛 / 戒備**。」

Meaning:

> react quickly to criticism by denying, justifying, or protecting oneself.

70. **get/become defensive = become self-protective in conversation (產生防衛心) **

> “There’s no need to get defensive.”

「沒有必要這麼**防衛 / 急着為自己辯護**。」

This is one of the most important family constructions.

71. **defensiveness = tendency/state of reacting defensively (防衛心) **

Practice 31

> “Her defensiveness made discussion difficult.”

「她強烈的**防衛心**令討論變得困難。」

K. COMPUTING / CYBERSECURITY

72. **defend a system/network against attacks (網絡安全) — 防禦攻擊**

> “Organizations need to defend their networks against malware.”

「機構需要**防禦惡意軟件對網絡的攻擊**。」

73. **cyber defence / cyber defense = 網絡防禦**

Broadly:

> technologies, processes, and practices used to protect systems against cyber threats.

74. **defence in depth = multiple cybersecurity layers (縱深防禦) **

Examples of layers may include:

- * authentication
- * segmentation
- * filtering
- * monitoring
- * endpoint protection
- * backups

The principle is:

> one failure should not remove all protection.

75. **defensive programming = write software anticipating errors/misuse (防禦式編程) **

A programming approach in which code anticipates:

- * invalid inputs
- * unexpected states
- * failures
- * misuse

and handles them safely.

76. **defensive coding = 防禦式程式設計**

Closely related to #75.

L. DRIVING / SAFETY

77. **defensive driving = driving to anticipate hazards (防禦性駕駛) **

Practice 32

> “The course teaches **defensive driving**.”

「這項課程教授**防禦性駕駛**。」

Meaning:

> drive in a way that anticipates mistakes or hazards created by other road users and conditions.

78. **defensive driver = 防禦性駕駛者**

A driver who actively maintains safety margins and anticipates potential hazards.

M. MEDICINE — DEFENSIVE MEDICINE

79. **defensive medicine = clinical actions partly motivated by liability concerns (防禦性醫療) **

A specialist healthcare/legal term.

It can refer to clinicians ordering extra:

- * tests
- * referrals
- * procedures

or avoiding high-risk cases partly to reduce perceived malpractice/legal exposure.

This is distinct from:

> immune defence.

N. FINANCE / INVESTING

80. **defensive stock = stock in a relatively stable-demand industry (防禦性股票) **

A **defensive stock** is generally a stock whose business is expected to be relatively less sensitive to economic downturns because demand for its goods/services is comparatively stable.

This does **not** mean its price cannot fall.

81. **defensive sector = 防禦性行業**

Often used for industries viewed as less cyclically sensitive.

This is investment terminology rather than a new base-verb sense.

82. **defensive investment strategy = 防禦性投資策略**

A strategy emphasizing:

- * downside protection
- * lower volatility
- * capital preservation

depending on context.

O. BUSINESS / CORPORATE STRATEGY

83. **defensive strategy = strategy aimed at protecting existing position (防守策略) **

A company may take defensive action to:

- * protect market share;
- * respond to competitors;
- * reduce exposure.

84. **defensive acquisition/patent strategy etc.**

The adjective is productively used to mean:

> primarily intended to prevent harm or preserve an existing position rather than expand aggressively.

These are compositional specialist uses, not separate dictionary meanings.

P. **DEFENSIVE**

85. **defensive = intended to protect against attack (防禦性的) **

Practice 33

> "They adopted a **defensive** position."

「他們採取了**防禦性**姿態。」

Opposite in many contexts:

> offensive

86. **defensive weapon / measure / structure = 防禦武器 / 措施 / 設施**

Designed mainly for protection rather than initiating attack.

87. **defensive play/tactics = 防守戰術**

Sports:

- > defensive formation
- > defensive strategy
- > defensive player

88. **defensive attitude = self-protective response to criticism (防衛態度) **

As above, psychological/interpersonal.

89. **defensively = in a defensive manner (防衛地 ; 防守地) **

Sport

> “The team played defensively.”

「球隊採取**防守型打法**。」

Conversation

> “‘I didn’t do anything wrong,’ he said defensively.”

「『我沒有做錯甚麼。』他帶着**防衛語氣**說。」

Same adverb, different contexts.

Q. **DEFENSIBLE**

90. **defensible = physically capable of being defended (易守的) — 可防守的 ; 易於防衛的**

Practice 34

> “They chose a highly **defensible** position.”

「他們選擇了一個非常**易守的陣地**。」

Military/geographical use.

91. **defensible = capable of being justified rationally (站得住腳) — 可以合理辯護的 ; 有理據支持的**

Practice 35

> “That is a legally **defensible** position.”

「那是一個在法律上**站得住腳 / 有理據可辯護的**立場。」

Practice 36

> “The decision is difficult but defensible.”

「這個決定雖然困難，但仍然**有合理理據支持**。」

This is now the more broadly useful figurative sense.

92. **defendable**

Defendable exists, but **defensible** is generally the more established choice for:

> able to be justified or protected.

So learner priority:

> defensible 

> defendable — lower priority.

R. **INDEFENSIBLE**

93. **indefensible = impossible to protect physically (無法防守的) **

> “The position became indefensible.”

「該陣地變得**無法防守**。」

94. ****indefensible** = impossible to justify morally/logically (無法辯護的) — 站不住腳的 ; 無可辯解的******

Practice 37

> “The behaviour was completely ****indefensible****.”

「這種行為完全****無可辯解 / 無法合理辯護****。」

Very common figurative adjective.

Often stronger than merely:

> wrong.

It says:

> no convincing justification can be offered.

S. ****UNDEFENDED****

95. ****undefended** = not protected from attack (無防守的) ******

> “The entrance was left undefended.”

「入口處於****沒有防守****的狀態。」

96. ****undefended claim/case** = not contested (法律 , 依司法制度) ******

In some legal contexts, an ****undefended**** action/claim means the opposing party has not filed or pursued a defence.

Terminology and procedural consequences depend on jurisdiction.

T. ****DEFENDER****

97. ****defender** = person who protects someone/something (保衛者) ******

Practice 38

> “He became a strong defender of free expression.”

「他成為言論自由的堅定**捍衛者**。」

This can be physical or ideological.

98. **defender of a cause/right = 倡議 / 捍衛者**

> defender of human rights

> defender of tradition

Meaning:

> someone who actively protects/supports it.

99. **defender — sports = 後衛 / 防守球員**

Already surfaced above, but a major independent everyday noun.

100. **public defender — legal**

A separate lexicalized legal compound, covered above.

U. **DEFENCE / DEFENSE — JUSTIFICATION**

101. **in defence of someone/something = supporting/protecting them (為……辯護)**

Practice 39

> “She spoke **in defence of** the proposal.”

「她發言**為這項建議辯護**。」

Practice 40

> “He came to his colleague’s defence.”

「他站出來**替同事辯護 / 解圍**。」

102. **come to someone's defence = defend them when criticized/attacked (替某人辯護) **

Very common.

> “Several colleagues came to her defence.”

「幾名同事站出來**為她辯護**。」

103. **spring/rush to someone's defence**

More vivid variants:

> spring to someone's defence

> rush to someone's defence

= 立即站出來替某人辯護 / 保護。

104. **a defence of something = argument supporting it (辯護論述) **

> “The essay is a defence of traditional teaching methods.”

「這篇文章是對傳統教學方法的一篇**辯護論述**。」

105. **put up/mount a defence = actively resist or respond (作出抵抗 / 辯護) **

Physical/sports

> “The team put up a strong defence.”

「球隊作出了強力**防守**。」

Legal/argumentative

> “He mounted a vigorous defence of his actions.”

「他強力**為自己的行為辯護**。」

V. FIXED EXPRESSIONS

106. **first line of defence**

Already covered:

> first protective barrier/response.

Physical, medical, technical, or figurative.

107. **last line of defence = 最後一道防線**

Practice 41

> “The goalkeeper is the last line of defence.”

「守門員是**最後一道防線**。」

Can also be figurative.

108. **on the defensive = responding to attack/criticism rather than taking initiative (處於守勢)**

Practice 42

> “The questions put him on the **defensive**.”

「那些問題令他處於**防衛 / 被動辯解狀態**。」

Sport/strategy

> “The team was forced onto the defensive.”

「球隊被迫轉入**守勢**。」

109. **go on the defensive = adopt a defensive attitude (轉入守勢)**

Can describe:

- * conversation
- * politics
- * business
- * sport
- * warfare

General meaning:

> start protecting/justifying rather than advancing.

110. **in self-defence / in self-defense = 為了自衛**

> “He said he acted in self-defence.”

「他表示自己是出於**自衛**而行動。」

Legal implications depend on context/jurisdiction.

111. **no defence / no defense for something = no acceptable justification (無法辯解) **

> “There is no defence for deliberately misleading customers.”

「故意誤導顧客是**無法辯解的**。」

112. **defend to the death = protect with total commitment (誓死捍衛) **

Often figurative/hyperbolic:

> “He will defend that opinion to the death.”

「他會**死守 / 極力捍衛**那個觀點。」

W. SPELLING

113. **defence vs defense**

British English and many Commonwealth varieties

> **defence**

American English

> **defense**

But:

> **defensive**

is spelled with **s** internationally.

Likewise:

- * defensible
- * defensiveness
- * defender

Not:

> **defencive** ❌

X. IMPORTANT DISTINCTIONS

defend vs protect

protect

is broader.

It means keep safe from harm.

defend

usually implies an identifiable:

- * attack
- * threat
- * criticism
- * challenge

Compare:

> sunscreen protects your skin from sunlight.

but usually not:

> sunscreen defends your skin

unless metaphorical/marketing language.

defend vs guard

guard

emphasizes watching/controlling access.

defend

emphasizes resisting attack.

> guard the entrance

> defend the building against attack

defend vs preserve

preserve

means keep something in its existing condition over time.

defend

means protect it against active threat/challenge.

> preserve historic buildings

> defend a building against attack

defend vs support

This is important for your passage.

support a practice

= approve/help it generally.

defend a practice

= support it specifically **in response to criticism or challenge**.

So:

> some people **defend this practice**

implies:

> other people have criticized it.

defend vs justify

justify

means show/prove that something is reasonable or right.

defend

means argue against criticism and in support of it.

You defend something **by trying to justify it**.

Exactly your passage:

> people **defend** the practice **by arguing that** students lack space.

defend vs explain

explain

simply makes reasons clear.

defend

tries to protect the action from criticism.

An explanation is not necessarily a defence.

defend vs excuse

excuse

often means reduce blame by explaining mitigating circumstances.

defend

may argue that the action was actually acceptable/right.

Compare:

> “I’m not defending what he did, but I understand why he did it.”

This means:

> understanding/explaining ≠ approving/justifying.

defend vs advocate

advocate

= actively promote/support a course of action.

defend

= respond to criticism or threat to that position.

One can advocate a proposal before criticism arises and defend it afterward.

defend vs argue

argue

= present reasoning for/against something.

defend

= purpose of the argument is to protect/support a challenged position.

So:

> defend X ****by arguing**** Y

is perfectly natural.

****defend vs resist****

****resist****

means oppose an external force/change.

****defend****

means protect something from it.

> residents resisted the attack

> residents defended the town

Different focus.

****defend vs fight****

****fight****

is broader active conflict.

****defend****

specifically focuses on protection or preventing loss.

An army can fight while attacking or defending.

****defend vs retaliate****

****defend****

= stop/prevent harm.

****retaliate****

= respond after harm/attack by striking back.

They are not equivalent.

defensive vs protective

protective

aims to keep safe.

defensive

often implies:

- * responding to attack;
- * preparing against attack;
- * guarding an existing position.

> protective clothing

> defensive military position

defensive vs offended

Common learner confusion.

defensive

= quick to justify/protect oneself from criticism.

offended

= upset because something seems insulting/disrespectful.

You can be both, but they are not the same.

defensive vs aggressive

defensive

= protecting/responding.

aggressive

= forceful/attacking.

But defensive behaviour can sometimes *look* aggressive because a threatened person reacts strongly.

defensible vs defensive

defensible

= capable of being defended/justified.

> a defensible argument

defensive

= intended for defence or showing self-protective behaviour.

> defensive tactics

> defensive tone

Very different.

defender vs defendant

Again essential:

> defender = 保衛者 / 後衛

> defendant = 被告

Y. GRAMMAR

114. **defend + direct object**

> defend the city

> defend the policy

> defend yourself

> defend your title

No preposition required.

115. **defend X against Y**

> defend the system against attacks

> defend yourself against criticism

Most productive threat construction.

116. **defend X from Y**

> defend crops from pests

Possible, especially when focusing on keeping harm away.

117. **defend oneself by + -ing**

Your passage-like structure:

> “She defended herself by explaining what happened.”

「她透過解釋事件經過**為自己辯護**。」

118. **defend X on the grounds that...**

Formal:

> “They defended the decision on the grounds that it was necessary.”

「他們以該決定有必要為理由**為其辯護**。」

119. **defend against + noun**

Intransitive-ish construction:

- > defend against attacks
- > defend against infection

The protected object may be understood from context.

Z. COUNTABILITY

defence/defense — activity/system

Often uncountable:

- > national defence
- > play defence
- > in self-defence

a defence — argument/protective response

Countable:

- > a strong defence
- > a legal defence
- > several possible defences

defences — protective structures/mechanisms

Plural:

- > coastal defences
- > immune defences
- > the city's defences

defender

Countable:

- > a defender
- > three defenders

defendant

Countable:

> a defendant

> several defendants

Family map

Family member	Main modern meanings
----- -----	

defend	protect physically; resist attack; argue in support; represent legally; prevent scoring; retain a title
defence / defense	protection; military system; legal case/side; sports defending; justification
defensive	protective; sports/military defensive; psychologically self-protective
defensively	in a protective/guarded manner
defensiveness	tendency/state of reacting protectively to criticism
defender	protector/supporter; sports defensive player
defensible	capable of being physically defended or rationally justified
indefensible	impossible to defend or justify
undefended	left without protection; sometimes legally uncontested
defendant	person/entity against whom legal proceedings are brought
defenceman / defenseman ice-hockey defensive player	
defensin antimicrobial peptide involved in innate biological defence	

Master comparison

| Form / sense | MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning |

defend — physical	保護某人 / 地方免受實際攻擊；保衛	
defend against	抵抗 / 防禦某種攻擊、威脅或傷害	
defend oneself — physical	自衛；保護自己	
defend — military	保衛領土、邊境、陣地等	
defend — argument	面對批評時提出理由支持 / 維護某個做法、立場或決定	
defend one's actions	為自己的行為辯解 / 辯護	
defend a claim/theory	用理由和證據支持某項主張 / 理論	
defend rights/principles	抵抗削弱 / 侵犯，捍衛權利或原則	
defend someone legally	在法律程序中為被告 / 當事人辯護	
legal defence	用來反駁指控 / 民事責任的法律抗辯	
the defence	法庭上的辯方及 / 或辯護案件	
self-defence	自衛；法律上亦可指正當防衛抗辯	
defend — sport	防止對方得分；防守	
defend a lead	阻止對方追平 / 反超；守住領先	
defend a title	再次參賽以保持冠軍身分；衛冕	
defending champion	正在衛冕的上屆冠軍	
defender — sport	後衛 / 防守球員	
defend a thesis	向考官答辯並以理據支持自己的研究	
thesis defense	論文答辯	
immune defence	身體抵抗病原體的免疫防禦	
plant/animal defences	生物防止捕食、感染等的防禦機制	
defense mechanism — psychology	心理防衛機制	
cyber defence	對網絡 / 電腦攻擊的防禦	
defensive programming	以預防錯誤、異常狀態和錯誤使用為目的的防禦式編程	
defensive driving	預判危險並保留安全餘度的防禦性駕駛	
defensive medicine	部分因法律責任風險而採取額外 / 保守醫療措施的防禦性醫療	
defensive stock	相對較不受經濟周期波動影響的防禦性股票	
defensive — personality	面對批評時急於自保、辯解或否認的	
on the defensive	處於守勢 / 不斷應付批評的狀態	
defensible — physical	可以有效防守的；易守的	
defensible — argument	有合理理據可以支持 / 辯護的；站得住腳	
indefensible	無法保衛；比喻上無法合理辯護、無可辯解	
undefended	沒有受到防守 / 保護的	
defender	保衛者、捍衛者；亦可指體育後衛	
defendant	被法律程序起訴 / 控告的一方；被告	
in defence of	為某人 / 某事辯護或維護	
come to someone's defence	在某人受到攻擊 / 批評時站出來替其辯護	
first line of defence	第一個保護 / 阻擋威脅的防線	
last line of defence	最後一道防線	
defend the indefensible	試圖為根本無法合理辯護的事情辯護	

For your original sentence

> “Some people **defend** this practice by arguing that” many Hong Kong students do not have quiet homes...”

The exact meaning is:

defend = 當把餐廳當補習場所的做法受到批評時，提出理由說明為甚麼這種行為仍可能合理、可以理解或值得接受

So:

> **defend this practice**

= 為這種做法辯護 / 替這種做法提出辯解理由

And:

> **defend X by arguing that Y**

= 以 Y 作為論據來為 X 辯護

The important contrast is:

> **explain a practice**

> = 解釋它為甚麼發生

versus

> **defend a practice**

> = 主張批評可能不完全合理，並提出理由支持這種做法。

For the core database, I would keep **7 major semantic branches** for **defend**:

1. **physically protect someone/something from attack**
2. **militarily protect territory/positions**
3. **argue in support of a criticized idea, action, decision, or person**
4. **legally represent/resist a charge or claim**
5. **sports: prevent scoring / protect an advantage**
6. **sports: compete to retain a title — defend a championship**
7. **academic/intellectual: support a thesis, theory, claim, or proposition against challenge**

Then the full family should explicitly index **defence/defense, defensive, defensiveness, defender, defensible, indefensible, undefended, defendant**, plus the established domain extensions in **immunology, psychology, cybersecurity, driving, medicine, investing, chess, and gaming** rather than collapsing them into a generic “protect” definition.